Spam Filters

To use or not to use? Spam filters—especially those with AI—work great, but do they really decrease your headache and increase your productivity?

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People have different reactions to spam. Some occasionally click on spam-looking messages out of curiosity; some just hit the [Delete] key; some use a non-learning spam filter and let it quietly do its job; some go all the way, training their Bayesian spam filters for months.

There's something about spam that triggers off a primal sort of hatred in us. If you think about it rationally, just how long does it take to delete all your junk mail, one keystroke at a time? Two minutes? Out of 24 hours? But still, we whine and groan at the spam "menace."

OK, it is indeed a menace, because if you put together all the man-hours dedicated to deleting spam, it actually makes a difference to the economy! It's been documented, at least in America: the total cost of spam in terms of lost productivity was $21.6 billion (Rs 97,000 crore!) in 2003, for 1.2 billion hours of lost productivity, according to Talkgold.com.

But forget the figures—you aren't bothered about the economy. The point is, what do you do with your spam? It probably depends on how much spam you get. The smart thing to do, of course, is to prevent spam from getting to your Inbox in the first place: use a dedicated junk mail account for Web forms, visit that account once a month, and delete everything (except the one or two valid mails that get there). Also, if you've got a Web site, put up your address in the format "agent underscore 001 at thinkdigit dot com"—spell it out instead of writing it the normal way.

It's when you must use your primary address that the spam problem—and therefore spam filters—come in.

Smart And Smarter

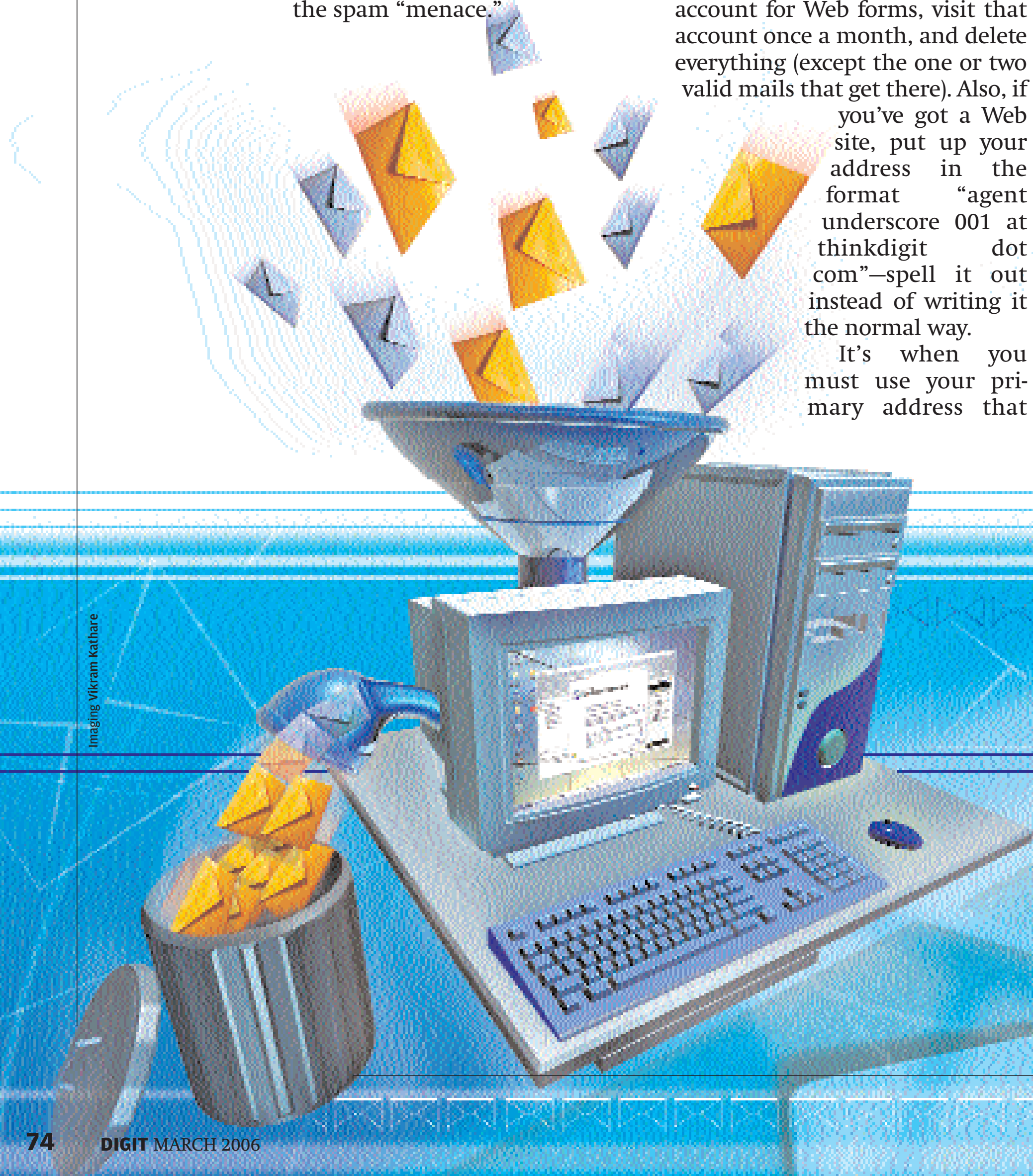
The first step is to consider using Outlook 2003, if you don't already. There's an inbuilt spam filter, and you can set it at two sensitivity levels—Low or High. High, of course, is stricter on what messages get through to your inbox.

Outook's spam filter is not Bayesian, meaning it doesn't use AI, and it doesn't learn from experience. There are several Bayesian filters available, which do learn from experience—including SpamBayes, POPFile, and K9, which is not an exhaustive list in the least.

There are a few small differences amongst the filters we've mentioned. K9, for example, is very light on system resources. Also, it doesn't ignore words such as "the" and "and", which could make a difference to the analysis. It has an interface of its own, which displays all your mail. SpamBayes and POPFile are pretty neck-to-neck in terms of fan followings, and use your Web browser as the interface. They also offer more configuration options than does K9.

Installation of these filters is straightforward enough—the only "tricky" parts are configuring your mail client's POP server address, and setting it to put the messages into different folders.

"Learning from experience" means you train the software—when you first install one of these



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